KVD-1. It came from the Isayev Design Bureau of Glavkosmos, the Russian rocket-making entity.

‘Don’t ask me why we did not label it thus,’ he said. ‘We just don’t want to show off.’

The ‘secret,’ he claimed was that the engine has a specific impulse of 461 seconds.

The specific impulse of an engine is a hallmark of its strength. The Americans had developed engines with much lower specific impulse. Russians were great engineers, but this claim of having an engine of 461 seconds sounded unbelievable.

‘You must be joking,’ I told him.

‘Come to Russia, and I will show you,’ he said.

Almost fifteen years later, now Russia beckoned.

As soon as we made inquiries with Japan in the late 1980s about their cryogenic engine LE5, the US, France and the USSR approached us. We roughly worked out that the deal should include sale of a few engines and technology transfer. The contract should be for seven years during which the foreign engineers would train us. We hoped to start making our own cryogenic engines in fifteen years.

General Dynamics Corporation of the US quoted around Rs 935 crore, which we found too steep. Aerospatiale quoted a slightly higher amount for a few engines and technology transfer by SEP Vernon. Glavkosmos of the USSR was too eager to collaborate with India, but were clueless about the money they should ask for. They finally quoted Rs 235 crore for two engines and technology transfer.

I favoured a Russian pact. This sentiment was shared by many in ISRO, and the India Government. Russians have been historically friendly to India, and India had reciprocated this camaraderie. Besides the government-to-government rapport fostered by the idea of socialism, I felt, there was something that made Russians and Indians natural allies despite stark differences in virtually everything from appearance to language and culture to cuisine.